MIŻIEN Claim Check 156 · Bathing water, Malta

‘Best in Europe’ to ‘bang average’?

An outlet’s headline claim, tested against ten seasons of EEA bathing-water data

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“Maltese waters have suffered a downgrade from best in Europe to bang average.”

Business Now (Robert Fenech), 17 August 2026
86 of 87 sites excellent in 2016 (3rd of 22 EU coastal states); 77 in 2025 (11th, level with the average).

VERDICT: LARGELY SUPPORTED

Right on the change; ‘best’ is third.

Draft for maintainer review
Status: no right of reply needed

TL;DR

Business Now's subtitle of 17 August 2026 says: **"Maltese waters have suffered a downgrade from best in Europe to bang average."** The EEA's classifications bear it out. Malta rated 86 of its 87 bathing waters excellent in 2016 (98.9%), third of the 22 EU states with coastal bathing waters, behind Slovenia (16 sites) and Cyprus. In 2025 it rated 77 (88.5%), eleventh of 22 and level with the EU coastal average of 88.3%. "Best in Europe" is generous for a third place, and the 'downgrade' is in the share rated excellent, not in safety: no Maltese site was poor in either year.

1. **The article's two Malta counts are right.** 86 of 87 sites excellent in 2016 and 77 in 2025, both as the EEA classes them. The other 2025 results are 8 good and 2 sufficient.
2. **'Best in Europe' is a fair shorthand, not literal.** In 2016 Malta was third of 22 coastal states (Slovenia 100% of 16 sites, Cyprus 99.1% of 112, Malta 98.9% of 87). It stayed in the top five until 2022.
3. **'Bang average' describes 2025 closely.** Malta's 88.5% sits 0.2 points above the pooled EU coastal share (88.3%) and in the middle of the ranking (11th of 22; ten states higher).
4. **The fall is in the top class only.** Every Maltese site met at least the directive's minimum standard in 2025, as in 2016. Rank is sensitive to small differences: Croatia, 12th, is at 88.3%.
5. **The week-13 figure is not tested.** The article's 56 of 87 excellent in week 13 of 2026 is from the outlet; we could not open the Directorate's weekly file. A weekly count is also not the same measure as a season class.



86 → 77
Maltese sites rated excellent, 2016 → 2025 (of 87)

3rd → 11th
Malta's rank among 22 EU coastal states

88.5%
Malta 2025 versus 88.3% EU coastal average

0 poor
Maltese sites rated poor in 2016 or 2025

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP
A ranking in 2016 that placed Malta first or a one-class gap to the leaders would move it to Supported; the EEA data do not show that (Malta was third).

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN
A different EEA count for either season; or a like-for-like EU average for 2025 that put Malta clearly above or below it (we find 0.2 points).

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1 Claim and sources

The article, “Water quality of Maltese beaches registers stark decline” by Robert Fenech, was published by *Business Now* on 17 August 2026. Its subtitle, in the outlet’s own voice, reads: “Maltese waters have suffered a downgrade from best in Europe to bang average.” This is a statement by an outlet about public data, not by an authority. Business Now says its figures come from the European Environment Agency and from the Environmental Health Directorate’s weekly updates [1]. We read the article through a summarising fetch tool, so details other than the subtitle wording, which the tool quoted exactly, are second-hand ◆ and every figure we rely on is recomputed from the EEA data.

Source	What it establishes	Use
Business Now, 17 Aug 2026 [1]	Subtitle wording; 86 of 87 excellent in 2016 and 77 in 2025; 56 of 87 in week 13 of 2026 ◆.	Claim wording
EEA bathing-water map service, layer 3 [2]	Class of every bathing water in every EU-27 state, seasons 2015–2025.	Primary statistical series
EEA Malta country factsheet 2025 [3]	77 of 87 excellent, 8 good, 2 sufficient in 2025.	Cross-check
Directive 2006/7/EC [4]	Classes and how a season’s class is assessed.	Method
Claim Check 005 [5]	Malta’s own series, checked site by site against a second EEA dataset.	Cross-check

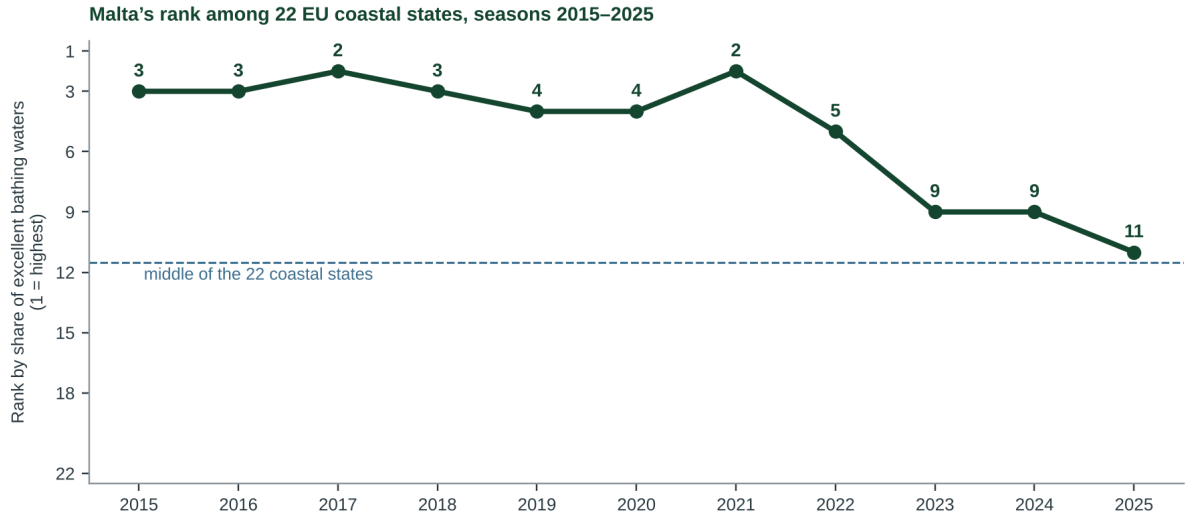
Method. From the EEA service we took the class of each of the 22,010 EU-27 bathing waters for 2015–2025 and computed, per state and season, the share rated excellent among waters with a class that season, for coastal waters (inland waters are excluded because Malta has none). A state’s rank is one plus the number of states with a higher share; ties share a rank. The pooled EU coastal share is total excellent over total waters. Malta’s counts equal those in Claim Check 005. Data and scripts: *data/cc-156/*, *tools/cc-156-report/*.

2 What the indicator measures

The Bathing Water Directive classifies each site as excellent, good, sufficient or poor from two faecal indicators, *Escherichia coli* and intestinal enterococci. The class is assessed on the samples of the season and the preceding seasons (normally four), so it is a statistical summary, not a single week’s reading [4]. ‘Sufficient’ is the minimum the directive requires. A fall from excellent to good is a real change in the faecal-indicator statistics, but it is not a fall below the standard. The article itself says that even an average result reflects a high level of safety ◆.

3 Malta against the EU

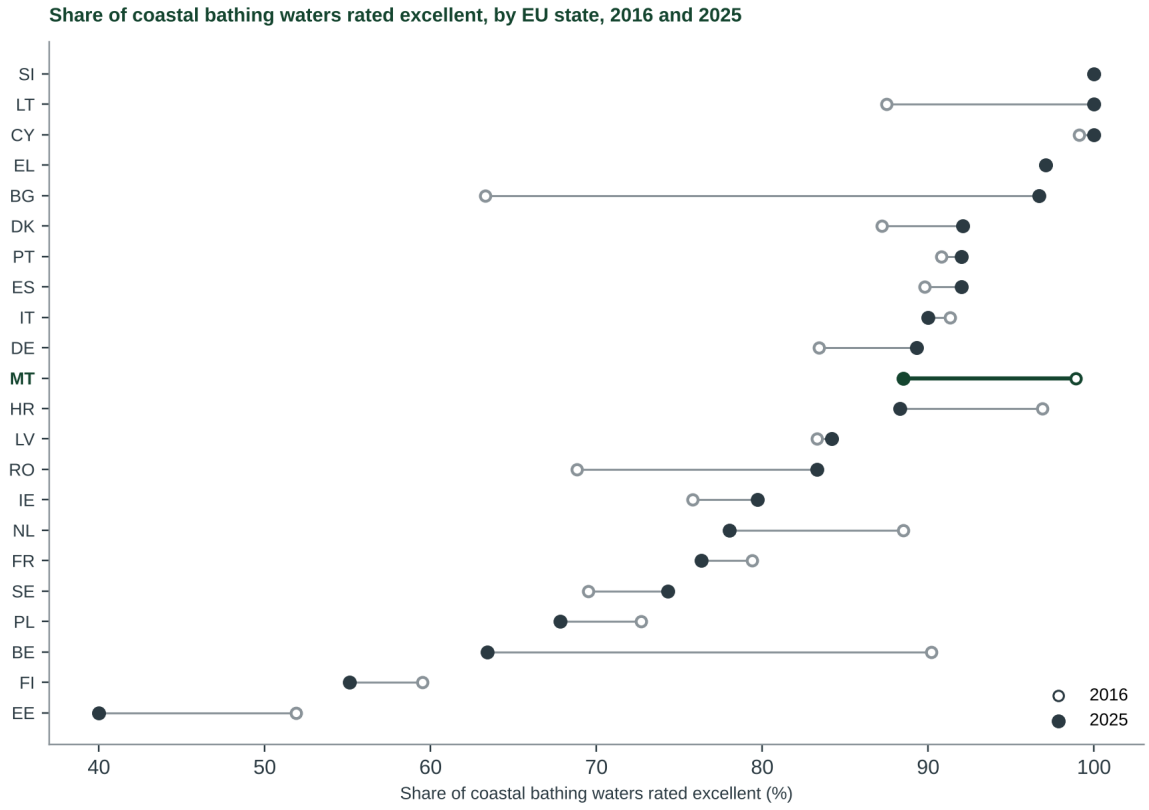
Malta's count fell from 86 excellent sites in 2016 to 77 in 2025. Over the same decade its position among EU coastal states fell from third to eleventh (Figure 1). Malta ranked second to fifth in every season until 2022, then ninth in 2023 and 2024 and eleventh in 2025. Counting all bathing waters, including inland ones, Malta went from third of 27 to ninth of 27.



Source: EEA bathing-water data, DiscoMap service BathingWater_Dyna_WM_2025 layer 3, retrieved 11 Nov 2026. Share = excellent ÷ bathing waters with a class that season, coastal waters of EU-27 states that report them.

Figure 1. Malta's rank by share of coastal bathing waters rated excellent, seasons 2015–2025.

Figure 2 shows each state's share in 2016 and 2025. Several states moved more than Malta in either direction: Bulgaria rose from 63% to 97%, Belgium fell from 90% to 63%. Malta's 2025 share (88.5%) lies between Germany (89.3%) and Croatia (88.3%), within 0.2 points of the pooled EU coastal share of 88.3%.



Source: EEA bathing-water data, DiscoMap service BathingWater_Dyna_WM_2025 layer 3, retrieved 11 Nov 2026. Share = excellent ÷ bathing waters with a class that season, coastal waters of EU-27 states that report them.

Figure 2. Share of coastal bathing waters rated excellent, EU-27 states, 2016 (open) and 2025 (filled).

4 Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Was Malta 'best in Europe' and is it now 'bang average'?

LARGELY SUPPORTED

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

In 2016 Malta's 98.9% placed it third of 22 coastal states, and in the top five for eight seasons (2015–2022); in 2025 it is eleventh of 22 with a share 0.2 points above the pooled EU coastal average. Both ends of the article's description match the ranking.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

Third is not first: Slovenia (16 sites, 100%) and Cyprus (112 sites, 99.1%) were ahead in 2016, and the differences at the top are one or two sites. The rank in 2025 is also fragile (Croatia at 88.3% is 12th), and 'average' rests on a share, not on safety: no Maltese site was poor in either year.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: the direction and size of the change are right and the endpoints are fairly described. 'Best in Europe' is a loose rendering of 'among the top three', so the verdict is Largely supported, not Supported.

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Malta was once ‘best in Europe’ for bathing water	2016: 98.9% excellent, third of 22 coastal states, behind Slovenia (16 sites) and Cyprus; top five until 2022 [2].	LARGELY SUPPORTED
B. 86 of 87 beaches were excellent in 2016 against 77 in 2025	EEA: 86 in 2016 and 77 in 2025 [2, 3, 5].	SUPPORTED
C. Malta is now ‘bang average’	88.5% against the pooled EU coastal 88.3%; 11th of 22 [2]. Average on the share rated excellent; every site passes the minimum standard.	SUPPORTED
D. 56 of 87 excellent in week 13 of 2026 ◆	Not tested: the Directorate’s weekly file could not be opened, and a weekly count is not a season classification, so it is not comparable with B.	NOT TESTED

6 Verdict and limits

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

Malta: 86 of 87 excellent in 2016 (3rd of 22 coastal states); 77 of 87 in 2025 (11th, level with the EU average).
Confidence: high on the figures, medium on ‘best in Europe’.

Why. The article’s counts are the EEA’s, and the EEA data show both the fall and Malta’s move from the top group to the middle of the EU ranking. The subtitle compresses ‘third’ into ‘best’, and it measures the top class, so ‘downgrade’ should not be read as unsafe water.

Limits. This check covers the bathing-water classification only, using data Malta reports to the EEA; it does not assess other pollutants, marine ecology or health outcomes, nor why individual sites changed class. Ranks depend on how many sites each state reports. Week-13 figures are untested.

Under our standards a right of reply is sought only where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted, so none is needed for this check. The report remains a draft for maintainer review.

References

[1] Robert Fenech, “Water quality of Maltese beaches registers stark decline”, *Business Now*, 17 August 2026. Read 11 November 2026 through a summarising fetch tool. https://businessnow.mt/water-quality-of-maltese-beaches-registers-stark-decline/

[2] EEA, bathing-water map service BathingWater_Dyna_WM_2025, layer 3 (class of each bathing water, 2015–2025). Queried 11 November 2026; data/cc-156/country_excellent_share.csv. https://water.discomap.eea.europa.eu/arcgis/rest/services/BathingWater/BathingWater_Dyna_WM_2025/MapServer/3

[3] EEA, *Bathing water quality in the season of 2025: Malta* (country factsheet), as cited in Claim Check 005. https://www.eea.europa.eu/en/topics/in-depth/bathing-water/state-of-bathing-water/bathing-water-country-factsheets-2025/mt-bathing-water-country-factsheet-2025.pdf/@@download/file

[4] Directive 2006/7/EC of the European Parliament and of the Council concerning the management of bathing water quality, Article 4 and Annex II. https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/?uri=CELEX:32006L0007

[5] Miżien, Claim Check 005 (92% excellent bathing water), data/cc-005/. https://github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/tree/main/data/cc-005

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	11 Nov 2026	First issue. No right of reply needed.